



Crowdfunding Strategies for Entrepreneurs, Innovators, and Self-Starters

GET FUNDED

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Introduction

Market forecasters see crowdfunding as an industry in its infancy. Despite drastic growth over the past few years, it still holds massive potential. As long as someone needs capital, crowdfunding will prosper. It combines the creative, the professional, and the social, and does so in an accessible manner. In fact, the very premise of crowdfunding – campaigns muster a large amount of low-value contributions over a defined period of time – helps projects amass loyal followings and grow publicly.

Typically, crowdfunding takes place online via an authorized portal. This allows project creators to link their social accounts and approach consumers anywhere in the world. For businesses, this opens the market right up. Niche innovators can now tap into an array funding models, no longer burdened by a lack of alternative. From music to film, science to real estate, and business to non-profit, crowdfunding offers a solution.

Putting financials aside, the secondary benefits of crowdfunding are significant. For one, a campaign is the ultimate marketing tool. A compelling project can dominate social spheres and leave supporters with a long-lasting impression. Even projects concerned with search engine placement, the links from a campaign lend authority to external ecommerce websites and blogs. The benefits, however, mostly boil down to the fact projects not only ask their supporters to buy in, but also to participate.

Many consider crowdfunding one of the most active forms of marketing because it establishes unmediated communication between supplier and consumer. In a non-professional setting, this means artists connect directly with their fans while non-profits rally together reachable communities. Simply, crowdfunding involves people in the creation of something great – and this excites them.

For startups, successful crowdfunding validates a concept. Similarly, startups gain entry to databases of accredited and non-accredited investors. That said, early-stage ventures pitching to amateur investors has stirred debate worldwide, particularly in the West. Countries that do embrace this form of crowdfunding, however, such as the UK, Canada, and many European nations, exude results more positive than negative. Questions of security and risk lead the pack of concerns, but many campaigns have already navigated around these obstacles and procured capital through the crowd.

Of course, all good things do come with a price. Should a campaign fail or defy expectation, it greatly injures that venture's future credibility. Crowdfunding timelines also leave no room for error or dawdling. Perhaps, this explains the fact nearly half of all campaigns fail. By no means is success a farce; it just demands a lot of time. Understand this well before launching a campaign.

Stretching oneself thin or failing to deliver on promises are both legitimate anxieties. Donation sources eventually stop giving, so the need for expansion grows direr each day the campaign ticks closer to its deadline – and many spectators await at the finish. Conversely, startups risk acquiring too many shareholders, all of whom have rights and influence the company's proceedings. With the wrong investors onboard, a startup's efficiency could degrade rather quickly.

All of these worries debunk the misconception that crowdfunding is free, easy money. Often, the process proves harder than the traditional means of garnering funds. Between transaction fees,

taxes, and other administrative expenses – all of which we will discuss – a lot of money goes to waste in the end. Project creators must invest themselves, both mentally and financially, to build ethos; they too need stakes in play for others to join in. So before asking the crowd for help, first look within yourself to see if you have the attitude, the resources, and the time.

With these matters in mind, I cannot stress the importance of crowdfunding education enough. It is a diverse and competitive industry – no campaign is the same. Allow the suggestions in this book to inspire, but not rule: A single formula does not exist, so incorporate your own creativity. Know that the industry does change often, so follow the news and stay informed. I suggest checking CrowdClan routinely, as this is an excellent resource for seasoned and inexperienced crowd-funders alike.



● THE FOUR COMMON MODELS



The Four Common Models

Wrapping up 2012, five hundred and thirty-six active portals existed worldwide, a number that has since skyrocketed due to an enormous amount of media attention and a Western push towards equity crowdfunding. Compared to 2004, for instance, crowdfunding-related headlines appear 9,990% more often today. Online forums continue to flourish year-over-year, so this number too rises steadily.

The public's general eagerness towards crowdfunding explains the current state of things: There are now over one thousand portals raising billions in capital each year. Industry experts believe crowdfunding will experience an additional 92% increase in 2014, equalling a 1000% growth over five years. With sustained progress, the industry could reach an annual value of \$500 billion by decade's end. Keep these statistics in mind as we explore the four main streams of crowdfunding in this chapter, along with each model's variants.

Rewards

The standard rewards-based campaign is rather straightforward. An individual posts a project, sets an obtainable goal, promotes its offering, and collects pledges in exchange for rewards. The size of the supporter's pledge determines the reward he or she receives. Depending on the portal, the project creator returns all funds should he or she fail to reach the predetermined goal.

This crowdfunding model maintains its popularity because it caters to artists, entrepreneurs, and innovators who need funds but wish not to part with equity or acquire debt. It also gives businesses an opportunity to test and/or launch products, engaging new markets and building a substantial social presence all the while.

Expanding the rewards-based structure, projects can also collect pledges monthly through subscription crowdfunding. This model typically runs long-term and requires a hefty lineup of add-on products. Similarly, projects may wish to produce installments, working casually month-to-month towards a larger goal. In many ways, this mimics the idea of a perpetual stretch goal – but more on that later.

Many startups view subscription crowdfunding as reliable revenue; however, endlessly releasing new products can be hard. As well, donor commitment is a major variable. Rather than a one-off donation, campaigns need to convince donors to pour money continually into the project. This means more creative and valuable rewards (forget novelties), plus one master goal to evade dry spells.

Donation

Most onlookers view donation crowdfunding as the simplest because unlike its siblings, donors receive nothing except a tax receipt and a slap on the back. As one would assume, this type of crowdfunding aligns perfectly with social causes and non-profits, as well as with charitable and political campaigns.

Crowdfunding is a great tool for non-profits looking to boost awareness and open new streams of revenue. That said, it necessitates a market approach much different from the rewards-based model. Since most non-profit projects have no products to push, they must entice supporters using rhetoric alone, showing donors the project's social benefits as well as the problem it strives to solve.

Equity

As the newest and most talked about version, equity crowdfunding promises to change the world's economic landscape. Although regulations – especially those in North America – currently bog down some portals, startups will rejoice soon enough as equity crowdfunding becomes a worldwide phenomenon. To date, this is a prevalent and successful model in Europe and the UK.

Instead of trading rewards for capital, businesses instead sell equity to investors, assembling a backbone of professional and amateur shareholders who anticipate an eventual return. Of course, this begets myriad concerns in terms of security, risk, and privacy. In later chapters, we will discuss the notion of safety in relation to filing taxes, licensing, incorporating, and more.

Branching off of the equity model, projects can also solicit “temporary” or “contained” equity through royalty-based crowdfunding. In this model, investors receive a percentage of a product or service's revenue over an agreed period. How many royalties depends entirely on the donation. This enables startups to raise capital without racking up debt or passing off shares. By promising royalties, startups also recruit sales agents: The purchaser's best interest is also to sell.

Departing with too many royalties, however, can permanently stunt a business' growth. Most investments fund the first wave of production and distribution, meaning a business too liberal with its revenue will find continued production and distribution unfeasible. To limit the risks, most portals stipulate a “buy-back” clause, building exits for companies should problems like this arise.

Debt

Another form of investment crowdfunding, albeit a less popular and glorified option, is debt, sometimes referred to as peer-to-peer lending. In this scenario, investors lend capital and expect a full return with interest by the end of a set term. Unlike rewards- or donation-based crowdfunding, debt primarily focuses on businesses with existing markets and creditworthy individuals.

Many debt crowdfunding contracts come at a lesser interest rate than through traditional banks. On top of this, the process is usually simpler and cheaper; many believe the outcome to be more controllable as well. In fact, a recent Crowds Unite study reveals that many Venture Capital firms favour this option. Last year, for example, two hundred and thirty VC firms spent 79% of the year's total investments (worth \$866M) on debt crowdfunding. Although in the shadows of equity, this model offers investors a lucrative opportunity too.

Did You Know?

Leisurely maul over the following statistics researched and compiled by GoGetFunding:

- Choice of platform is one of the strongest factors influencing a project's success
- Featured projects, specifically those on major websites like Kickstarter, have an 89% chance of meeting their target
- Campaigns with concrete daily schedules generate 180% more money
- The most successful timeframe for a project is twenty to forty days, though websites like Indiegogo disagree and suggest forty-five
- Equity crowdfunding projects pull in more funds per project than donation- or rewards-based campaigns
- Pitches between three hundred and five hundred words raise the most funds
- Approximately 78% of all completed campaigns earn more than their original goal
- Campaigns that frequently update raise 126% more compared to those that do not



● PHASE ONE: THE PRE-CAMPAIGN STRATEGY



Phase One: The Pre-Campaign Strategy

Two to three quarters of your campaign's workload should precede the launch, so leave a minimum of three months to prepare. During this time, allocate entire mornings, afternoons, and nights – sometimes all three – to work on the project. Those who cannot wholly dedicate their schedules to crowdfunding will find it much harder to raise funds.

By your launch date, you should have a solid understanding of how each day will play out. Expect to improvise on occasion, however, as markets shift radically without notice, both in and out of your favour. Mark the biggest events of your campaign on the calendar but allow minor things to pass along in the moment. Together, we will define both the major and minor “things” in this chapter.

Develop the Project's Foundation

The most successful crowdfunding projects promise functional finished products. While some do crowdfund “beta,” reserve the testing phase for before your campaign. Show your audience an offering well underway, one that can believably move from development to production with the crowd's support. Prototypes are an excellent way to display your idea so long as the funds raised go towards improving, finalizing, or bringing it to the market.

For equity crowdfunding, the same principle applies. Investors want to see traction. Prematurely listing a startup will not attract investors. As much as creativity counts, an investor's criteria are stringent. Startups must at least establish revenue and validate the concept before listing. Beyond a crowdfunding goal, equity campaigns must also cogitate aspects like overhead expenses, legal proceedings, licensing, and so on. Calculating such things begins with knowing the demands of the audience, both in the professional and consumer world.

The Business Plan

The standard business plan format makes liberal use of headings, subheadings, indexes/appendices, charts/tables, and other navigators. In other words, business plans are orderly, detailed, and logical. In effect, they refine a project's core. Although only equity portals insist startups submit business plans, rewards-based projects also benefit from writing such documents.

The traditional business plan touches upon the following areas, with emphasis on those most appropriate to the startup or project.

1. Overview and Executive Summary: Write the executive summary last; it encapsulates the report's main deliberations. Laying your points out first allows you to formulate a succinct, objective summary. The overview too previews all other sections. Like most projects, you need not complete the steps linearly so long as the order comes out correctly in the end.
2. Company Description: Delve into the specifics here — the business' goals, visions, mandates, beliefs, and so on. Talk about both the history and state of the startup, profiling each team member as you would in a resume. Define the startup's structure and size, along with all of its other HR operations. Do mention the products and services, but skip lengthy preambles and irrelevant story telling. Editing this section will consequently shape the “wow” in your campaign.

3. **Industry, Market, and Strategy:** Investors want to know how you plan to reach customers, so provide them with a roadmap. Demonstrate your knowledge and experience through your business plan's accuracy, forethought, and execution. In this section, illustrate your startup's potential by pointing out the opportunity (i.e. a marketplace void or demand that your product satisfies).

4. **Budgets and Financial Projections:** Scrutinize all financial details and format the results into easily digested tables, charts, maps, and paragraphs. Some investors go straight to this section, which is why experts suggest spending 80% of your time on calculations and projections. Incorporate at least three years of statements into this section.

Moving away from tradition, another popular startup tool is the Business Model Canvas, a highly interactive approach. It offers entrepreneurs a stellar opportunity to explore their businesses visually. The method is less tedious, more portable, easily revised, forcibly concise, and entertainingly effective. That said, the traditional approach has merit we cannot disregard. At any rate, a typical Business Model Canvas passes through the stages below.

1. **Customer Segments:** The people and organizations your startup intends to target, including all paying customers and partnerships. Overtly define the market as well (i.e. niche, mass, diversified, etc.).

2. **Value Proposition:** The products and services offered to customers that create value. Such value distinguishes your startup from its competitors.

3. **Channels:** How do you connect with your customer segments? In other words, how do you advertise?

4. **Customer Relationships:** Describe the type of customer interactions you uphold. For example, would one categorize your product or service as automated or "do it yourself"? Similarly, what type of customer support (technical service) does your startup employ? Will that change or improve after crowdfunding?

5. **Revenue Streams:** The ways in which your startup turns profit and covers administrative expenses (i.e. sales, subscriptions, loans, grants, advertising, and so on).

6. **Key Resources:** Your startup's infrastructure, along with all of its other assets. Resources may come in various forms and are crucial to a startup's sustainability.

7. **Key Activities:** How your startup executes its value proposition.

8. **Key Partnerships:** Your startup's buyer-seller contracts, professional networks, mentors, investors, mutual alliances, and joint ventures.

9. **Cost Structure:** The total cost of operation, including both fixed and variable expenses. Consider the economies of scale and scope.

The Lean Canvas model branches off the above, grouping everything into two main categories: Product and Market. The model primarily inspects the problem-solution dynamic, though in a way best suited for early-stage startups. Due to a lack of detail, many investors require supplementary material if given a Lean Canvas plan.

The Safety Net

Across the world – majorly in the US – investor protection is a popular topic. To allay fear within the equity crowdfunding community, governments continue to draft rules and regulations. Universally, portals now demand complete startup transparency as a precaution. Campaigners should proceed cautiously in this respect because revealing too much could invite intellectual theft.

Although it's important for supporters to comprehend a project, they can grasp the concept without the exact science. If you want further assurance, though, simply file for a patent, copyright, or trademark. Some vehemently disagree with patenting, claiming that the process is harmful and anti-social. Nonetheless, projects can still use this to retain original ideas. Yes, the process is expensive, but as the idiom goes, "Better safe than sorry."

Equity projects should also ask investors to sign a non-disclosure agreement. Most portals include this clause in their service terms, but a contract alone does not grant full immunity to harmful behaviour. Instead, always monitor your investors: The last thing you want is a clamorous shareholder flaunting sensitive information. Luckily, you can reprimand these actions legally.

On the topic of legality, consult a lawyer or accountant when in doubt. The rules vary country-to-country, so campaigners might benefit from a little extra guidance or direction. This goes for international platforms as well. Like the market, regulations change, so stay cognizant of the developments.

The Goal

Every project requires a realistic financial goal. For equity crowdfunding, slapping a round number on the listing scares investors away – true budgets go down to the decimal. Rewards-based crowdfunding projects, however, can boast a goal ending with zeroes for effect. (Think of the cliché fundraising thermometer). But just because these campaigns lack specificity does not mean they can bypass research.

Investors and supporters expect project creators to have stakes in the campaign – at least 5% to 10%. Planning, creating, and marketing all cost money, so the quality of the campaign reflects your commitment. On top of the aforesaid expenses, also factor in portal fees, shipping and handling, taxes, web hosting, and the myriad other management operations. Explain these expenses in detail in the financials section of your business report.

With an attainable goal in place, identify benchmarks and coordinate marketing events for each. Doing so moves the campaign along and eliminates plateaus – but more on this later. Bear in mind each portal's maximum and minimum contribution limits; tailor your events to each level as to not favour one tier. Aim to collect oodles of small- to average-sized contributions, while urging the big industry players to buy a few of the top incentives. For equity crowdfunding, however, reverse this logic. Watch how many shares you depart with and how many shareholders join in: Life after crowdfunding can become unmanageable otherwise.

The Team

People often regard rewards- and donation-based crowdfunding as a solo or partnered activity. According to Indiegogo, though, team-based campaigns actually raise 94% more funds than projects run individually. But startups already know the power of teams. In fact, a project's team adds to or diminishes its credibility. Understandably, accomplished and diverse team members lend more than inexperienced ones. They contribute to the campaign's skillset, increase the network size, and divide the labour.

Based on your own project, find individuals that will enhance the campaign's efficiency. Some general roles include manager, technician, administrator, marketer, public relations representative, and accountant. In niche industries, the position possibilities narrow. But teaming up does not necessarily mean individuals either – projects can ally with other projects that hold the same attitudes, beliefs, and ambitions. In other words, keep an open mind.

The Pitch

Can you explain your project in two minutes or less? If not, you have work to do. Begin by breaking down your offering into simple terms. Then, while in its most basic form, find the main objective. Once defined, read your pitch aloud to a friend unfamiliar with your idea. Do they fully understand it? Err on the side of professionalism, but abolish jargon. Elaborate all uncommon terms and favour short, clean sentences. Although your crowdfunding page can contain large amounts of content, you can share succinct pitches more easily with others.

The Brand

Nothing distinguishes a project better than its own brand. Brands unify campaigns in the minds of supporters and non-supporters alike. To pull off this effect, however, it must encompass more than just a fancy design. A project's brand must operate on different levels. Think logos, colours, sounds, fonts, shapes, and more.

For instance, imagine placing print outs of your logo, website, press release, and business card (to name a few) on a giant display. Does each piece complement the other with no apparent contrasts or inconsistencies? Sadly, many fail this little test, exhibiting an eclectic mix of promotional material. But even well designed campaigns can challenge a brand's central message. For this reason, ask yourself if these adjectives apply: Honest, consistent, authoritative, persuasive, approachable, responsible, transcendent, attractive, responsive, and representative.

As an aside, those with coherent branding, abide by your themes, styles, and principles when communicating online – both for personal and professional reasons. Refrain from posting controversial or contradictory subject matter, regardless how humorous or interesting.

The Website

Construct a website, or in the very least a landing page, that attractively introduces and explains your project. Pay special attention to the homepage so that it invites further exploration. Despite the fact that portals dedicate space to project set up and promotion, an external traffic generator never hurts. Before and during a campaign, branded websites refer traffic to the crowdfunding page. Afterward, they assume a more pertinent role in converting and retaining customers.

Purchase an appropriate domain name before setting up your corner of the web. Choose a domain that contains either your project's name or a relevant keyword. Then, optimize it. Learning a few search engine basics helps you to drive traffic onto your crowdfunding page from otherwise unreachable areas. Run a routine blog on this website and amass a list of email addresses to further your social position. After your campaign, redirect your attention to things like link building to carry this momentum forward.

Examples from the Crowd:



Breaking the equity crowdfunding record at £1.9m, Kevin McCloud recently added six hundred and forty new investors to his company, Hab Housing Limited, via CrowdCube. Departing with 29.29% equity in exchange for 90% more than his original goal, McCloud's business proposal gives projects something to aspire towards.

Before approaching the crowd, McCloud's business already collected various awards and recognitions, all of which investors could find on the website. His gallery of past projects added appeal too. Through discussions like "why do we bother," McCloud identified the market's need and demonstrated growth by advertising current employment opportunities. Together, these things created another dimension of professionalism.

Another notable CrowdCube campaign is Crowdfunder, the UK's leading crowdfunding network. Crowdfunder evinced the power of reputation and traction when it gave investors the chance to get involved, offering 10% equity at £500,000. Within only fifteen minutes, the campaign received £230k; within three-and-a-half hours, the full £500,000 poured in from the hands of over two hundred investors. Crowdfunder stands as an example of how much it pays to know your market and have your market know you.

Define Your Audience

You might not know this, but supporters rarely discover projects on their own. That means it's your responsibility to lead them. Once there, allow your compelling rewards and enthralling story to do the rest. Before we delve into these topics, though, let us first single out your audience: What values and interests they hold and how to win them to your side.

Start by probing your idea's many facets. Generally ask yourself, "Who does my project appeal to?" In the business plan, startups must concretely answer this question. For those uninterested in lengthy documents, at least brainstorm the demographics and psychographics of your imagined consumer – age, location, gender, nationality, income, education, occupation, belief system, lifestyle, personality, interests, and so on. Thoroughly understand what makes your audience tick, so to speak. This means finding a problem and proposing a solution. It could also mean finding a void, a missed angle, an opportunity for improvement, or something of this nature. By the time you nail down your primary audience, you will also know how to reach your different customer segments.

Positioning

Focus on creatively approaching your audience. Banality is the bane of crowdfunding. Gather as many ideas as you can, weighing the pros and cons of each. Anticipate reluctance and refusal among your customer segments. Plan to encounter (and overcome) obstacles like communication barriers, financial limitations, economic conditions, and foreign policies.

The more planning you do, the better prepared you will be overall. Keep in sight the fact your campaign must create value for its supporters. The end-goal may be to fund your own ambitions, but donors and investors need to see value too. How you do this is up to you entirely, but remember that clearly defined benefits are much more convincing.

To gain perspective, assess your competition's market position. Do not ignore the happenings in your industry either. As unpredictable as the market may seem, research can locate openings that benefit you. In terms of competitive analysis, pick apart other companies' brands, offerings, and infrastructures. Learn from their mistakes and successes.

During your investigation, trace your market's upward and downward trends, both in terms of monetary and social value. Since you calculated your budget earlier, you can now attend to the social fads around you. For instance, which hashtags perform best in your industry? What content goes viral? How hostile is the environment? Leverage this knowledge to the best of your ability.

Lastly, communities regulate their own languages, so build ethos accordingly. To some extent, it is acceptable to use multiple personas in order to diversify your customer segments so long as the campaign ties back to an overarching brand and objective. As a rule, never deceive or manipulate – only negativity can come from this.

Testing

Some crowdfunders may find this step excessive. However, campaigns that promote via paid advertising know that static marketing yields less than dynamic: Static in the sense of a single strategy over a set duration; dynamic in that the position adjusts to the trends and behaviours of the crowd.

One popular method of dynamic marketing is A/B testing. With your landing page, design two separate appearances and write two unique messages, or calls-to-action. Show half of your audience one version, the other half the second, and measure the conversions (click-through to crowdfunding page). Leave in place whichever proves most effective. Continue this process, refining the poorest model as well as the best, eventually reaching a version vastly improved compared to the original set. Doing so increases your chance of success exponentially.

Market testing can boost your social activity as well. Experiment with different trends, participate in numerous groups, share diverse content, and measure the success of each (i.e. likes, shares, retweets, and other social statistics). Use past and current campaigns as social benchmarks and employ new strategies to meet and exceed these successes.

Reaching

According to Biz Community, nearly one-third of the world's population will engage social media by decade's end. That equals a few billion people. As a crowdfunder, you need to reach only

a fraction of this number. Plenty of successful projects end with under one hundred supporters, a handful of which the project creator knows personally. So don't fret if you only gather a small following at first. Just find a niche community – a thriving segment of your industry – and build genuine relationships, ask for recommendations, and step into new circles. Stay up-to-date, attend both online and in-person events, and follow the trends studied in previous steps.

Generally, no one wants to donate first, so you need to glean a significant portion of your goal prior to launching your campaign. Indiegogo calls it the “green bar effect,” while others know it as the 30% rule. Whatever you choose to call it, getting backers to pre-commit generates a snowball-like effect during the first official week. Members of your network see the campaign's immediate progress – the green bar inching towards the finish – and feel compelled to join in.

With that original 30%, your campaign stands a 90% higher chance of success. But this takes more time to assemble than most realize, so set aside a minimum of three months to pull your network together. For equity campaigns, the challenge is more daunting because the first investors influence all to follow. A lineup of accomplished, respected investors raises a startup's value, while conversely, a bunch of amateur investors reflects poorly. Equity campaigns need their leaders to lead from day one, unlike rewards-based crowdfunding, where big donors can help recover from a plateau midway. We will elaborate on this idea in later chapters.

One trick for gaining followers is to involve yourself in relevant discussions and gain authority by becoming a perceived expert. Without mentioning your long-term intentions, make connections and toss out ideas here-and-there, testing the water, so to speak. Once in tightly with the community, pitch your crowdfunding campaign to gauge your primary network's interest. Those unsavvy with marketing and social media should do this as far back as nine months.

The more authority you and those in your community hold, the larger your market reach. Credibility thwarts doubt, simple as that. Thousands of unknown connections will not produce this effect, so demonstrate your competency through what you post and promote alone. Whenever possible, seek out opportunities to showcase your knowledge too such as interviews and presentations.

Example from the Crowd:



Via Kickstarter, the Buccaneer, a 3D consumer-level printer, garnered \$1,438,765 between May 30th and June 29th, 2013. But here's the remarkable part: The project surpassed its funding goal of \$100,000 in only ten minutes. By the end, three thousand five hundred and

twenty backers jumped onboard. How did they manage such success?

The Buccaneer began promoting three months in advance. To supplement their social media efforts, they also constructed a website and got in touch with some powerful people. At the top of the project's crowdfunding page, a list pops up naming its many endorsers: Reuters, Mashable, Cnet, Yahoo! Finance, TechHive, TechCrunch, and International Business Times (to name only a few).

Upon reading the rest of the pitch, you will quickly notice the simplicity and ingenuity of the language. For instance, the headings – “why our project matters” and “why we need you” – beckon support by placing the power in the audience's hands. Furthermore, the project breaks down technical ideas into simple concepts, offering a thorough walkthrough of the printer.

Because of the detail, backers could trust the product would work and that they would receive it in the end.

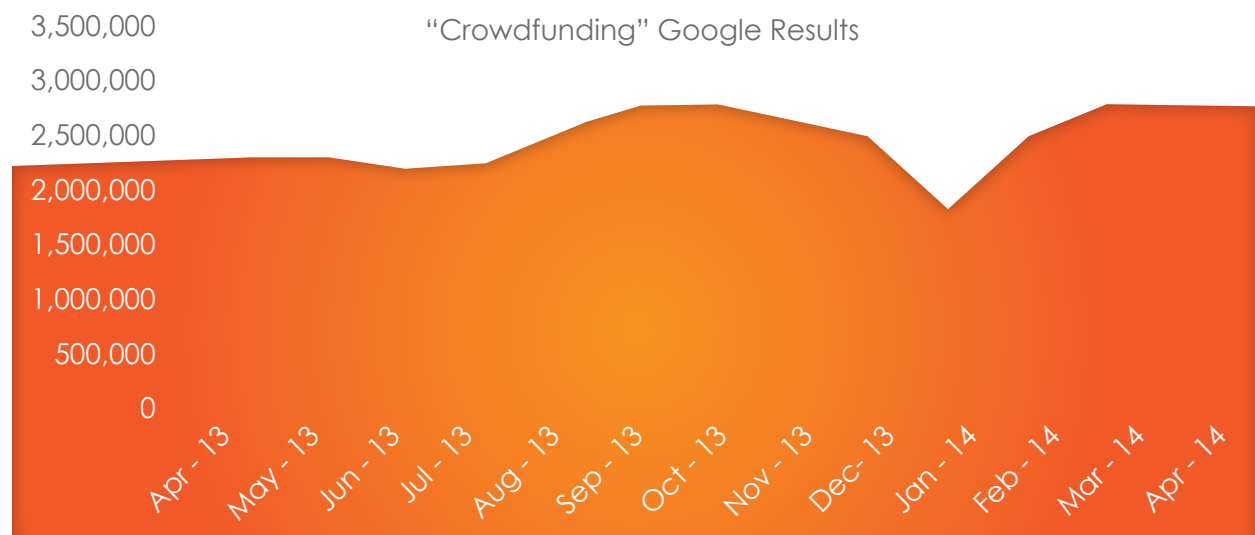
Time Your Launch

Time-based campaigns start and end around a specific event. They simply borrow popularity from that chosen date to raise awareness. Charities, for example, can build donation campaigns around local holiday fundraisers, pulling resources from both within and outside of the community. In a sense, most campaigns are time-based in one way or another, but for sake of this discussion, the term refers only to themed campaigns.

Some crowdfunders cycle through time-based campaigns to perpetuate a larger year-round project. Commonly, businesses and creative projects do this through subscription platforms or run them independently. To pull this off, campaigners should stagger their incentives, switching things up month-to-month. Coordinating time-based with yearlong campaigns is important; though, attempting simultaneous crowdfunding is not for the weary.

Trends

Time-based campaigns can orient a trend or season. To determine which date works best, think back to your goals. When do you need the money by? Work backwards from there, leaving ample time for marketing. Now, with a range in mind, consider your audience's lifestyle. Youths, for example, take summers off, whereas the working-class only break on weekends and holidays. That said, avoid ending on major holidays: People make other plans, so you lose last minute funders.



Source: "Crowdfunding." Google Keyword Planner Results. Google Adwords: Retrieved May 2014.

In relation to your audience, pinpoint your industry's biggest months. Research market reports to calculate the most fruitful time for you to crowdfund. One research approach, as demonstrated above, is to map keyword searches pertaining to your project (i.e. "3d printing," "wearable technology," etc.). For the sake of this example, the chart above plots the term "crowdfunding," as searched on Google between April 2013 and April 2014. If we launched a campaign in respect to this data, it would start in August or end in November.

Expand your research by consulting your portal's calendar and blog. Are there upcoming developments that may affect your launch? Keep in mind that niche portals feel market fluctuations the most, whereas large portals promise consistency and security. Stay mindful of the competition's timelines as well. Overlapping indicates poor planning, unless part of a larger scheme.

Interactions and Activities

Program your campaign's "interaction dates" in a way that corresponds with upward trends. Examples include meet-ups, webinars, forums, Q&As, and online games. Strive to host at least one event per social portal, respecting the nuances of each. In other words, your LinkedIn event should contrast your Twitter event. Whenever possible, let people speak with you in-person too, though physical events cost money – so budget smartly.

Stretch Goals

The Kickstarter community first coined the term "stretch goal," but it has since spread globally. Simply, a stretch goal, as implied by the name, targets a goal exceeding that of the project's original. Instead of cutting off funds after success, a project introduces new objectives in attempt to procure extra capital. Should the campaign fail, there are no financial repercussions. Only some portals allow this tactic, though, and not all campaigns suit the strategy. In fact, since stretch goals only add to or improve an offering, some campaigns may be limited in their options.

Note that stretch goals merely embellish; they in no way threaten the integrity of the original product. A board game, for instance, adds expansions that change neither the game's premise nor design. Instead, the project could offer alternatives (gameplay, rules, and/or editions) and accessories (pieces or players), but not an offering large enough to support its own campaign (another game in the series).

Before adopting stretch goals, consider the cost of producing and distributing more rewards and the burden of an extended campaign. Sometimes it is wiser to launch a second follow-up project, as we will cover a bit later.

Example from the Crowd:



After completing a Kickstarter project in 2012, Cloud Imperium Games and Roberts Space Industries (RSI) Corporation turned to IgnitionDeck, a DIY crowdfunding WordPress plugin, to continue raising funds for their famous video game, Star Citizen. Today, midway through the month of May 2014, Star Citizen strives to achieve its fiftieth stretch goal, valued at \$44 million. Whether or not the project hits this point makes no difference – the campaign has already earned its title as the world's most successful crowdfunding project.

On the company's website, they expound their project's intentions concisely: "Star Citizen is aiming to be the first AAA game developed with money from fans instead of a major publisher. Money pledged to Star Citizen goes directly to the game's development needs. Stretch goals will unlock additional features, rewards for current backers and more as we attempt to make this dream a reality." Review the project's past stretch goals for examples and ideas before making your own.

Enliven the Campaign

Steps in this final section speak primarily to rewards- and donation-based crowdfunding. However, the concepts regarding content are universal. These elements animate things discussed in previous sections; they make the difference between standing out and falling into the background. Let's see how to make a pitch compelling, emotive, professional, and accurate.

Note! Depending on your project, this step may come before or after choosing a portal. If you wish to select a platform first, skip ahead to the next chapter.

The Perks

Perks, sometimes called incentives or rewards, present value to supporters. Commonly, projects arrange a series of six to nine representative rewards – those that reflect the brand or concept. Of all the planning stages, this is among the most distracting. Careful not to saunter into territory infeasible and extravagant.

Pozible's Handbook suggests \$50 is the most popular perk price-point. Accommodate the high- and low-ends of this average. Do not exclude small supporters: They comprise the majority of your network. You have up to nine products, so set benefits for big and small donors alike.

When designing perks, ask yourself, "What does my project have to offer?" The most successful projects promise tangible rewards, but depending on the campaign, this does not always work. Envision creative ways to incorporate your brand and message into useful perks, while, at the same time, steering clear of default items like mugs and T-shirts. The product itself can also be a great way to pull in donors, but beware of "pre-selling" tax implications. In most cases, this constitutes as revenue (taxable income).

Customize your perks within reason. For example, as a writer, I could give supporters an author's note, signature, alternate ending, limited-edition cover, bookmark, interview, or live reading – all things that do not exhaust my resources and can be personalized. As well, for mass-appeal, I could enable e-book downloading, reserving print copies for those above the \$25 level. Find avenues to increase the value of your project through its rewards, even with items as simple as the ones suggested.

Clever equity projects will take these ideas and combine them with their listing. And why not? Investors can be consumers too. In fact, some amateurs have yet to decide which they are. Try increasing the allure of your company with discounts and programs. Typically, an investor buys in because he or she believes in or likes the startup, so preferred treatment can add intrinsic value. Running a rewards-based campaign, then offering consumers the chance to own shares, parallels this concept.

Returning to the main discussion, place limits on certain rewards. Doing so points traffic to the mass-appeal products. Let's go back to the example above: Assume I offer three interviews, five live readings, twenty limited editions, one hundred bookmarks, and unlimited e-books. (Obviously, those numbers would change depending on my market research, but the idea's there). The "limited-time only" or "while quantities last" ploy repeatedly appears in advertising because time constraints force people into immediate decisions. Use this to your advantage.

In addition to setting limitations, explore your delivery options. Compact designs cost less to ship;

they also require fewer materials to make. But even the soundest design can encounter problems. A well-planned project should foresee possible perk-related issues and respond ahead of time. Tech rewards, for instance, could include bug patches, software updates, and manuals. Now you see why simple rewards equal less stress for the campaign.

Free perks – something that costs next to nothing to reproduce – can convert non-backers into avid supporters as well. In other words, those who choose not to contribute financially, but promote your campaign anyway. A character profile or sketch, for instance, suits the purposes of my hypothetical campaign. It's quick to make, easy to distribute online (scan and email), and closely related to the project. Free incentives boost promotion so long as they do not take away from the paid perks.

The Video

According to Kickstarter, half of projects with videos receive funding, whereas only a third of projects without videos succeed. Although not really the same, equity projects too should think about videos. Even if directed entirely at the consumer audience, videos open another medium to claim authority.

While certain guidelines exist, this part of the campaign depends a lot on your own tastes. Rarely do cookie-cutter solutions come together, so why would video be an exception? Web search “top crowdfunding videos” or peruse your portal for high-ranking projects. Quickly, you will see big quality differences between those receiving funds and those not.

Generally, shoot videos three minutes or less. It's not a lot of time, so brainstorm and storyboard long before the first take. Compose a concise, convincing message, easily represented in a matter of seconds. On your crowdfunding page, you have additional room to explain concepts in detail, so only include the essentials. Introduce the purpose and premise of your project right away, later previewing the key incentives available to supporters (if any). Conclude with a clear call-to-action.

Filming a video may be a new experience for some, so maul over a few of these guidelines along the way.

- Storyboard the entire video
- Reread the script and ask others for feedback
- Enunciate clearly, confidently, and loudly
- Eliminate pops and crackles in the audio
- Film in a well-lit environment, preferably one that's controllable
- Get to know your equipment's features
- Use interesting angles and motions without distracting the viewer (i.e. zooming, panning, tilting, transitions, etc.)
- Frame the presenter appropriately by learning the rules of spacing and positioning
- Consider the placement of all objects in-focus and in-frame
- Coordinate colours and fashions to match your campaign's brand
- Choose your soundtrack carefully

- Select fonts used in other promotional material
- Shoot multiple takes
- Use a functional editing program

Video and audio quality are paramount. Thankfully, consumer-level equipment continues to drop in price, both for rental and purchase. Some smartphones even contain excellent on-board cameras. Bear in mind that cinematography has a world of its own; there are always experts who can help.

The Content

A pitch – the content displayed on the crowdfunding page – needs to touch upon the five W's: Who, what, where, when, and why. Lastly, weave-in "how." To elaborate, this means introducing yourself, narrating a story, describing the purpose, setting parameters (i.e. launch/end date), and outlining the benefits. The "how" comes at the end, both for when instructing donors how to pledge and expounding on how the project works. The more specifics the better – but make it entertaining, moving, or thought provoking. Additionally, attend to whether or not your product comes with a warranty or can be returned. This becomes a headache for some after the campaign, so reduce the stress by thinking ahead.

To render your content easier on the eyes, write with the following tools and techniques.

- **Organize:** In HTML, you have six heading sizes, so structure your pitch with multiple levels. Organization improves the readability of a page as it enables scanning. It also grants the writer freedom to tackle complex ideas and convey meaning logically and efficiently.
- **Chunk:** Essentially, chunking refers to paragraph simplification. In other words, short paragraphs centred on a single idea. Always lead with a topic sentence and transition into the next paragraph, nesting the main point within a two-to-three sentence core. This gives readers the chance to digest preceding sections before moving forward.
- **Format:** Use bold and italic typefaces modestly. Similarly, if possible, draw quotes and statistics out from your copy using pull-quotes and sidebars – any techniques that focus in on pertinent details.
- **Reference:** Your crowdfunding page cannot fit everything. Link out to external webpages to expand big ideas and avoid clutter.
- **Narrate:** Successful project creators often say emotion outdoes professionalism. What does this mean? It means that some projects – equity campaigns excluded – prefer to throw around casual, personable language. For one, this style of writing is friendlier. It is also easier to understand. Sophisticated language cloaks, whereas plain language unveils.
- **Edit:** Pick strong verbs and nouns – those that evoke imagery or stir emotion – and arrange them in short tidy sentences. This connects with chunking, as mentioned earlier. Try reading your pitch aloud too; the eyes sometimes miss mistakes.

Extend the concepts above to graphics. Images break up text and make copy aesthetically pleasing. Furthermore, they assist in explaining tricky subject matter. They say a picture's worth a thousand words, so what does that make an infographic? Combining imagery and words adds insurmountably to a project's pitch, especially one of a technical nature. Graphics are also necessary for presenting perks.

But what about content written by others? This is important too. Approach influential members of your network and ask them to cover your project. Pitch to journalists, online bloggers, and reviewers all the while. Publish a press release, write guest blogs, and update your social profiles incessantly as this inspires others to write on your behalf. The initial wave of reports and articles will revolve around your press release, so follow this format: Date of release, title and tagline, location and portal, announcement, key details (most important first), about, and contact information.

Some services change the model above. PitchEngine, for example, publishes interactive press releases, composed of both text and multimedia. Such formats can fair better socially, but understand that a traditional press release often goes further in the newsroom.

Example from the Crowd:



During its fifty-seventh week, American Gut pulled together \$505,000+ through FundRazr. As an ongoing venture at three thousand three hundred and ninety-eight backers, it will be interesting to see how much higher the project can climb. Already crowdfunders hail American Gut as “the world’s largest open-source science project.”

The project’s pitch is quite simple. In fact, it breaks down into a bulleted list by the end. Although more headlines and shorter paragraphs could have delivered a stronger reading experience, the call-to-action is abundantly clear. American Gut also acknowledges a crowdfunding page’s restraints and leaves the densest content for an external website. This makes the project accessible to everyone.

For better examples of infographic use, simply search for the best and worst tech-based crowdfunding projects. You will learn how to present and how not to present technical and scientific information during this search.

IV

● IMPORTANT PORTAL CONSIDERATIONS



Important Portal Considerations

Some large portals receive thousands of hits a day. Unfortunately, the likelihood of swooning all visitors is small; it's too easy to fall into the background. Conversely, many niche portals promise greater conversions because of narrowed user interests. Regardless of size, campaigns need to spend time networking outside of a portal's database. Picking a portal based solely on its traffic will not guarantee success.

Placing size aside, let's go over an assortment of areas related to portal selection. As much as traffic is important, there are so many more variables, so start brainstorming with the following in mind.

- **Accessibility:** Can funders simply search your project and retrieve its contact information? Can project administrators export the portal's user data?
- **Fees:** Apart from how much money the portal deducts, investigate the transaction tools available. Expect an additional 3-4% in payment processing fees. For debt crowdfunders, find out if any payback restrictions exist (i.e. overpaying monthlies).
- **Incentives:** Does the portal help distribute, produce, or promote perks? Can projects offer their own rewards or must they select from a portal bank?
- **Integration:** Since networking plays such a vital role in crowdfunding, check how easily supporters can share the webpage. Similarly, how many of your own social accounts can you link? Explore the streams of communication between crowdfunder and supporter (i.e. email, instant messaging, or video chat).
- **Models:** Know what benchmarks success and what consequences come from failure. Determine the portal's crowdfunding model (i.e. all-or-nothing) and acknowledge the funding minimums and maximums. What are the steps involved in setting up a campaign?
- **Reputation:** Read various reviews, including those from major media sources and minor forums. Culling information from a well-rounded database helps projects see the full picture. From there, estimate success rates, conversion rates, and other useful metrics. Research the type of users on each portal, particularly for startups seeking seasoned investors.
- **Security:** Especially for equity crowdfunding, portals store scads of sensitive information. Verify such data stays private. Inquire what security protocols are in place (i.e. SSL encryption) and look for certificates and other marks of authority. For equity, is the portal a registered broker-dealer? Lastly, what legal services are available, if any?
- **Support:** Consider troubleshooting and maintenance. Where can you turn to for assistance?
- **Tools:** Look for portals that conduct administrative duties for you. Will your project have access to analytics for measuring activity? Review the interface to make sure it is compatible with all of your needs. Also, pop by other project pages to see how they have made use of the space.
- **Usability:** Appearances are very important – and so is usability. Navigate the website and judge its structure for yourself. Does the portal display on mobiles and tablets? Can projects design fundraising pages without extensive knowledge of web design?

**Consult the Appendix for example crowdfunding portals.*

The DIY Alternative

Should you wish to avoid major portals, you may opt to crowdfund independently using your own domain and resources. This means dropping the 3-9% commission fees, but also losing access to useful tools and networks. Perhaps, for projects desiring full customization, this trade-off is acceptable.

For smaller projects, however, handling marketing, payment processing, and other administrative responsibilities can inundate the team. With extensive knowledge of social promotion and SEO, campaigns can pull in sufficient traffic, but funds may trickle in at a slower rate. It is also possible to run longer campaigns, and this may benefit many projects.

Overall, DIY crowdfunding is good for practice. Projects can learn the ropes, so to speak, as long as they recognize the higher risk of failure. As well, it is limited to donation - and rewards-based crowdfunding at this time; the legalities surrounding equity would be tough to get around. If this method still interests you, start your research at SelfStarter or Crowdhoster.

Money Talk

Familiarize yourself with the various transaction-processing systems on the market, especially in terms of cost, popularity, and reliability.

Some popular services include Amazon Payments, BancBox, Bitcoin, PayPal, Stripe, WePay, and VerifyValid. Research which service(s) your crowdfunding portal uses and incorporate the fees into your goal. Remember also to open an account with whichever service(s) your portal accepts.



● REGISTRATION AND SETUP



Registration and Setup

Quickly, let's review some common hoops portals ask users to jump through. Hold off completing the following until reading the proceeding section, "Phase Two: The Launch."

Note! DIY projects must follow the instructions provided by the third-party service. For instance, a user or installation guide may accompany a plug-in, so consult that instead. Websites like Prosper, however, give projects the option of creating and embedding campaigns directly from the website. Understand the limitations and freedoms of the DIY option before moving forward.

Rewards and Donation Platforms

1. **Create an Account:** Many portals permit users to login through social profiles like Facebook and Google+. If you choose this method, go into your account settings and fill in any missing details.
2. **Title:** Come up with a short, catchy title for your campaign.
3. **Locations:** Choose your city and country. Some portals operate internationally, while others are country exclusive.
4. **Pick a Category:** Niche portals bestow fewer project categories than mainstream platforms. Select subcategories whenever possible.
5. **Funding Type:** Some portals fund projects differently than others do. For instance, some follow the flexible funding model, in which campaigns keep funds regardless of success (usually in exchange for steeper fees), while others strictly use the all-or-nothing model. Understand the disadvantages and advantages of each.
6. **Image:** Upload an image for your campaign. Look at the portal's recommended dimensions and crop or enlarge accordingly.
7. **Description:** Do not mistake your short description – tweet length usually – for your pitch. Instead, capture the essence of your campaign in a sentence or two.
8. **Duration:** Specify your start and end date, if applicable. Portals like FundRazr do not require a completion date.
9. **Goal:** In the appropriate box, type in your crowdfunding goal. Watch out for currencies and punctuation. One British pound, for instance, is unequal to the Canadian dollar. Similarly, a decimal in one currency or language could mean a comma in another – or vice versa.
10. ***Rewards:** Structure your rewards. Include a price, photo, and description. Within the description, if asked for, mention the estimated delivery date. Of course, this section does not concern donation-based crowdfunding projects.
11. **Narrative:** Copy your pitch into the browser so that its format stays intact. Along with your content, upload the video and all other visuals. Not all portals support HTML or allow image embedding, so layout your content to the best of your ability. Some platforms also suggest including a "Risks and Challenges" write-up. Transparency's an asset, so write honestly and in a positive tone.

12. Links: Create paths to your website, blog, and social profiles. You may link to fellow/partner organizations too.

13. Theme: Very few portals allow projects to alter the page's colour scheme. If you have the option, respect your brand. Same goes for typefaces.

14. Accounts: Fill out your payment forms and set up your accounts.

Equity Platforms

1. Offering Memorandum: A legal document outlining your campaign's objective, terms, and investment opportunity. Along with this submission, attach all other legal forms, properly completed and authorized.

2. Financial Statements: Typically, a three-year financial forecast as well as a description of previous capital raises. Describe your intentions with the crowdfunded capital if not already specified in the memorandum.

3. Business Plan: Although sections of this document may seem redundant, provide all the information about your business nonetheless.

4. *Pitch: A succinct description of your investment opportunity viewable by investors. By this point, start designing your online space by uploading photos, logos, and videos. Look over the steps involved in rewards- and donation-based crowdfunding for inspiration.

5. Submission: Before a project goes live, portals review the offering. If compliant with all laws and terms, the crowdfunding campaign commences.

Debt Platforms

1. Personal Information: The portal uses this information to ballpark your lending rate and check for fraud. Submit your credit report as a part of this step; the inquiry will not affect your score.

2. Loan Listing: A loan listing acts as an application — it provides information on the size and type of loan desired. When selecting a size, understand lower amounts typically receive more funding. Both personal and business loans are available, ranging from a one- to five-year amortization period. Keep in mind investors read your listing, so make it enticing.

3. Answer Questions: Some portals set questions for you to answer. Complete them honestly, showing investors your willingness to disclosure additional information.

4. *Title and Description: Again, refer to the rewards- and donation-based crowdfunding walkthrough; though, do explicitly state your intentions with the loan.

5. Financial Situation: Essentially, this section demonstrates your creditworthiness – your ability to cover monthly payments. Talk about your job(s), debts, and commitments to demonstrate your spending/saving habits.

Risks and Challenges

How a contributor perceives risk is one of the most significant factors determining a project's success. This is because backers understand crowdfunding concerns and respond positively to projects that do not try to hide them. Instead, donors appreciate transparency; Guarantees do not improve the allure of a project, but rather suggest a lack of pragmatism.

On the topic of risk, consider how easily you can setup a crowdfunding project. Typically the simpler the process, the less screening involved. Some projects may wish to submit only to websites supporting carefully selected campaigns; others just want a place to fundraise. Weigh the challenges both environments pose.

VI. PHASE TWO: THE LAUNCH



Phase Two: The Launch

Right before the launch, reconvene with your team and lineup your materials from phase one. Mentally prepare for what's to come. A smooth transition not only sets the stage for what lies ahead but also the morale of everyone involved. Already you have completed the bulk of the work, so now it boils down to execution.

Go back over everything: Make sure you have not missed a step. More importantly, wrangle up your supporters and verify you have at least 30% of your goal satisfied. Now, with that behind you, shift your focus towards the remaining 70%. Categorize your connections in the following way before launching. In addition to these categories, label each connection according to their expected contribution – big, small, repeat, or unknown.

1. The Steadfast Supporter: He or she will undoubtedly pledge funds or invest. Of all categories, this individual is most likely to donate more than once.
2. The Probable Backer: He or she is someone who you can rely on to show up week one, but whose donation will be no more than average. Aim for quantity here, not necessarily "quality." By quality, I mean heavy social influencers or corporate icons. The probable backer must only fall into the background, paying his or her dues while handing the message off to a friend or two.
3. The Neutral Follower: He or she teeters on the fence, unsure whether to commit or not. Those in this category play no part in the initial 30%, though this does not mean they are lost. In fact, the neutral follower becomes a target in the last week of a campaign – but more on that later.
4. The Dubious Donner: He or she shows reluctance but still participates within the network. At this point, those inactive do not fit into any category. Since this rejects a massive amount of potential backers, access these unknowns through your steadfast supporters and probable backers. Introductions are always valuable.

Note! For equity crowdfunding, categorize investors based on their financial standing – accredited, non-accredited, ordinary, eligible, and so on. Based on their portfolios, estimate the amount of shares these individuals intend to purchase. Furthermore, look at their experience and rank according to value. Value, in this instance, means usefulness to your startup (i.e. a relevant skillset or impressive record of accomplishment).

During the first week, you want at least 80% of those in the first two categories to come through. Of the steadfast supporters, however, place aside a few with deep pockets; they may serve well at the end of the campaign. For equity projects, parade the recognized, seasoned investors around the first week. Doing so draws other investors to the startup – like herding sheep, so to speak.

With enough tact and dedication, you may even transform hesitant supporters into evangelists. Certain angles appeal to specific types of people, so exercise variety. To put it another way, if your network grows, so do the odds in your favour. Social studies estimate that a leap from one hundred to one thousand Facebook friends could drive the chance of success up by 20%. Even after the first week, such statistics exemplify the need for continuous network expansion.

Keep in mind that the average crowdfunding endeavour only reaches its target on the thirty-sixth day of a forty-seven-day campaign. This marks three-quarters of the way, at which point, if you still have 20% or so left to fundraise, you can still encourage more donations. We will talk about this in detail at the end of the chapter.

The First Day

Recall our discussion on time-based crowdfunding. If you never determined a specific date, but rather a week or month, then postpone your campaign until a Tuesday or Wednesday morning. According to CauseVox, donations peak during these two days. Additionally, plan your finale for a weeknight or weekend. When getting to know your audience, plot their time zones; otherwise, you may launch during the afternoon or night unintentionally (maybe even obliviously). But we've digressed – let's get back to the first day.

By opening your crowdfunding project early- to mid-morning, you elongate the window for first day donations. Not only do you capitalize on lunch break internet surfers, but you also give your supporters ample time to check their email and finish their daily tasks. Conversely, publishing at night, you risk losing first day donations – maybe not altogether, but certainly some.

Assuming you listen and launch in the a.m., do yourself a favour and complete the following before 5pm.

1. Social Notification: Across all social profiles – the crowdfunding page and your blog included – tell the world the game is underway. Craft this announcement carefully, balancing excitement and persuasion. If you feel so inclined, you could squeeze this step into the planning stage, but harnessing raw in-the-moment emotions can be so much more effective than a message thrice contemplated.
2. Welcome Email: Hopefully, by now supporters will have inundated you with emails, inquires, and requests. Send a welcome email to everyone's personal and professional inboxes who have shown interest. Think of this as an invitation to join the categories of "steadfast supporter" and "probable backer." Preview things to come to build anticipation and tell them more emails are on the way. By the laws of common courtesy, however, pen an "opt-out" or "unsubscribe" link at the bottom of the email.
3. Thank You Message: Someone needs to donate right away, even if it is just your mother, father, brother, or sister. For equity, coax a local angel investor or VC into initiating the campaign. Regardless who, send them a thank you message – an acknowledgement goes a long way. For some supporters, you may write these in advance, but for the mass majority, a template will suffice so long as it does not read devoid of human emotion or gratitude.

Likely, you will notice a rapid increase in social activity, at which point you might want some help. Social media management services do just this, but refrain from complete automation. Computer generated messages harm campaigns – they lack emotion. Instead, just schedule the publication of pre-written messages. For instance, set a few updates to release during your shut-eye. Here are a few services to help you on your way: TweetDeck, HootSuite, SocialOomph, Tweepi, Spreadfast, Buffer, Bitly, and Everypost.

The Content Routine

In previous chapters, we spent time gathering resources and consolidating ideas. However long that took, multiply the duration by four. The new number stands for how long you should spend promoting all of your new content. This rule applies to material created after the launch as well.

1. **Blog Content:** Blog topics should orient your project's progress, research, and market. An equity project's blog would typically run on a self-hosted website (i.e. corporate commerce page), whereas a filmmaker could get by on Tumblr. Blogging is a tool for growing email lists and informing contributors. Create catchy titles and write in a way that invokes a response from the reader. Most importantly, invite them to return!
2. **Broadcast Emails:** Send campaign updates via email, highlighting key developments in the project. Resist redundancy in relationship to the blog's content. Use this as a special opportunity to generate feedback and conduct readership polls. A thank you message suits the email format, but include a public shout-out as well.
3. **Social Updates:** Routinely publish on your social portals. Depending on the platform, these can go out on the fly. For example, if you attend a social event, Tweet updates in real-time and upload photos to Instagram. Involve your connections as much as possible during the campaign to rally additional support and to show appreciation.
4. **Infographics:** Infographics are easily shareable – not to mention, bloggers like to post about them. Creating lots of visual content around your campaign can also boost traffic and brand recognition.
5. **Guest Posts:** A correlation exists between the number of outside links to a crowdfunding page and its chance of success. One way to collect links is to guest blog on authoritative websites. Landing an article on a popular website's homepage can achieve more than a local journalist conceding to tell your story. This is because guest posts are generally unmediated, meaning the scoop comes from you unfiltered.

Projects that update every five days earn four times more money than those updating every twenty. If you fall behind at the beginning, then increase your update frequency. Revamp underperforming social portals too; a new position may raise an unexpected following. Most portals offer analytics, so brood over new ways to optimize conversion and click-through rates pointing towards your campaign. Analysing also helps produce better content – it becomes apparent what does and does not work.

The Paid Approach

If you have the budget for it, run a Pay-Per-Click (PPC) advertising campaign. Online businesses implement PPC regularly because it can markedly boost traffic. The concept is straightforward: Publish an advertisement on an eligible website and pay the owner per click or per impression. Be warned, however, that online marketing comes with its own lexicon. I advise learning more before pumping dollars into a campaign.

Sites like Stumbleupon, Reddit, and Facebook promote advertisements too that target niche markets more-so than search engine alternatives. The boldest campaigns can undertake both,

supplementing a paid run with blogging and other organic techniques. Sponsoring events and contributing to like-minded projects produce similar effects locally, so allocate funds for both online and offline endeavours.

Before tossing dollars at a marketing firm, pinpoint an optimal time to begin. For instance, running a PPC campaign in the planning stage seems useless: Visitors cannot yet donate, nor will many of them ever return (unless a part of your network). Similarly, a third of your campaign's funds trickle in during the first week, kicking things off to a strong start. Perhaps, then, hold off on paid advertising until the middle. By the final few weeks, however, it's likely too late.

The Final Stretch

Never despair if your campaign nears its end with funds still to raise; there is ample time on your side. A late success is always achievable. In fact, a slow middle period happens to lots of projects. Community Funded even coined a term for this scenario – the “Valley of Death.”

Essentially, the “Valley of Death,” sometimes called the “U” curve, refers to the period of sluggishness between the first and second funding peaks. The first peak – your initial 30% or so – blasts the campaign off in a good direction. Unfortunately, the rules of gravity often catch up, and following the first peak, funding sometimes decreases.

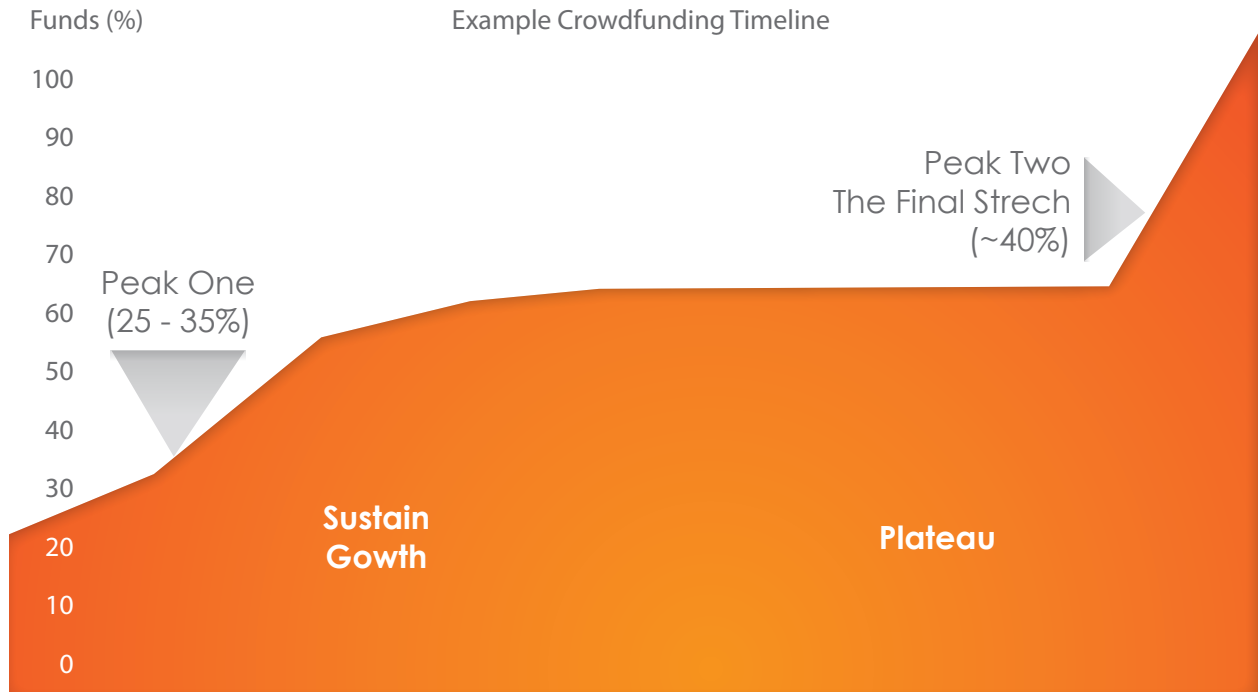


Source: *Roadmap to a Successful Project. Community Funded Report.*

Enter the Valley of Death, an area difficult to climb out of. Here, just before the second peak, the project somehow reanimates its supporters, encouraging a new wave of funds that pushes the campaign into its final stretch.

Know that the members of your first and second peaks come from within your immediate networks. Never rely on strangers. Roughly 10% of all donations come from unconnected supporters; the rest are people directly motivated by you. And one way to motivate those lagging behind is to give them something to watch.

Reserving a handful of wealthy friends can gentle the Valley's slopes. With one or two huge donations, non-supporters suddenly see value in your campaign. Psychologically, they believe they missed something back when the campaign first launched. These donations, however, must soar above average; otherwise, this will not work.



Source: *Roadmap to a Successful Project. Community Funded Report.*

In the final week, consider introducing one last surprise. For example, propose a bonus reward – something affordable and shippable – to those who already supported or discount incentives. After rolling out these final steps, draft two messages.

Firstly, send a thank you email to loyal supporters. Be positive and excited in this email. Let them know where things stand: How close the project is to completion, any new incentives or developments, and what to expect after the campaign. Secondly, distribute a reminder email to the inactive members of your network. This includes media contacts and donors alike. The last minute scramble can get hectic, so plan accordingly. If you have a full-time job, for example, book this week off in advance, anticipating the worst-case scenario.

Example from the Crowd:

Feed the Keepers

The Indiegogo project, *The Keepers* – a film depicting the “lives, hearts, and minds” of zookeepers – managed to excite \$7,000 in the campaign’s last four days, roughly half of its entire goal. Because of some last-minute promotional efforts, not only did the campaign satisfy its \$15,000 goal, but it also exceeded it by \$700.

One technique they employed was the “Final Countdown,” which gave supporters the chance to save the project. Here, they simply let people know the stakes: What they stood to lose and what supporters had to gain. *The Keepers* discovered how to scale the Valley of Death with honesty, simplicity, and sincerity.

VII. ● PHASE THREE: THE WRAP-UP



Phase Three: The Wrap-Up

Let's establish a theme for this final section – communication. Up until now, communication has been principal, but moving into the third phase, it is arguably the most important time for regularity. Why? Because you have finished the campaign – the funds sit safely in your pocket – and supporters now expect you to uphold your side of the deal.

Once the portal disburses the funds, you must rise to the occasion and deliver on your promises. Planning a successful campaign is one thing, but planning one that continues to bloom is entirely another. Any misguided steps at this stage amplify in the limelight, so tread carefully as you pilot these final areas of the campaign.

Production and Distribution

Fulfilling your rewards and promises takes priority in this final phase. Thankfully, you planned to do this on day one. Portals like to make this phase lighter by assuming some of the work. Upon campaign completion, portals send out all of the information you need to ship rewards and thank backers. If the portal does not supply sufficient information, however, simply broadcast email a request to supporters for more details.

With a confirmed list of names and addresses, check with the various postal systems in your city, looking for discounted rates on international and bulk shipping orders. Sometimes, supporters all live within the same area, so deal-hunting pays off. Planning for this ahead of time is nearly impossible, but getting to know the different systems' rates and processes helps.

Since you cannot account for sales precisely, your original plan will inevitably change. That said, careful not to oversell. If you agree to deliver an obscene amount of perks, expect to face delays – so respect your tipping point. If you find a flexible manufacturing or shipping company, however, you can leave quantity to chance.

When in trouble, tell your backers. Never switch perks to meet deadlines. Deceiving disappoints and breaks the trust, both things that reflect poorly in the media. According to a CNN Money Report, 84% of Kickstarter's top fifty projects shipped late in 2012, so take solace in the fact delays happen to everyone. Diagram your supply-chain process so that your backers can track their perks. This is one way to compensate for delay.

Communication is not always about the bad, though. Have fun with the production and distribution phase, taking pictures and writing stories each day. Humorous anecdotes concerning the design lab or factory build intrinsic value around the rewards. It's one of the great things about crowdfunding. Instead of the standard click-to-buy, supporters experience the life of a project from beginning to end.

Equity

Equity campaigns differ slightly. Again, portals do disburse investor information, but you then must file with the government within thirty or so days (timelines vary country-to-country). Next, you have to sign the proper certificates to transfer equity. Once you polish off the paperwork, the funds finally exchange hands and the real journey begins. These investors now possess shares, so ongoing communication is paramount. Look forward to things like dividends and other payouts down the road too.

Momentum

A finished campaign continues to receive visitors. These visitors can no longer donate, but this does not mean they cease to hold value. Linking a website to a crowdfunding page is two-sided: Firstly, it provides additional information to backers during the campaign; secondly, it diverts traffic to an active website after the campaign. So for a business “pre-selling” via rewards-based crowdfunding, the website later points visitors to an ecommerce page.

After a successful marketing run, your product and brand will rise in search engine activity, so get ready to ride this momentum. It's now up to you to funnel traffic to another location, as your crowdfunding page likely sits at the top of search engines. To begin this transition, post an update stating that you plan to carry the project forward elsewhere. Then, the portal acts as both a landing page and referral source. The best part is that each visitor's first impression is of your successfully run campaign!

When dealing with previous supporters, gradually changeover from campaign development emails to general project newsletters. This phase deals with retention, not necessarily conversion, so offer useful information. Still chat about new products and releases, but begin to appeal to a wider audience to grow your subscribers. Through email, notify or remind customers of promotions and recommend new products. Also, obtain information from every wary traveller to reduce your project's bounce rate and enrich your market data.

For equity campaigns, the game splits after crowdfunding. On one side sits the consumer market, and on the other the investors. While working to build a larger customer base, you must simultaneously produce quarterly reports, reviews, and other documents to satisfy the investors' needs. Maintaining both relationships can be a challenge, but every startup goes through this.

Second-Round Crowdfunding

With one success packed away, perhaps another project looms ahead. For rewards-based crowdfunders, contemplate equity crowdfunding a few months after the wrap-up. Contrarily, equity crowdfunders can expand by pre-selling products rather than soliciting shares.

A number of successful crowdfunding projects return for round two simply because the foundation is there already. That said, a second campaign necessitates a new approach; otherwise, backers are less inclined to pledge again. The responsibility falls on you to create a new concept, rewards structure, story, and marketing scheme, leveraging only your existing brand and database in the beginning. A second campaign commences roughly around the 30% target, meaning more than half of the work still lies ahead. Never assume one success guarantees another – this kind of thinking leads to carelessness and laziness.

Do not run back to the crowd if you fail to establish a second revenue stream. Crowdfunding capital only lasts for a short period, so projects need to establish new capital avenues for stability. Especially for rewards-based projects turning to equity, financing will not happen if investors see little progress between the first and second campaign.

Accountability

Most equity crowdfunding portals perform due diligence to differentiate an honest project from a fraud. They do so to assay a project's chance of long-term success as well as its market readiness. Rewards- and donation-based portals often emphasize the fact that users must discern a campaign's worthiness for themselves and that they do not interfere with a project's affairs.

Some portals do tout "legal recourse" in the Terms of Use, but this generally does not protect backers entirely. In saying this, projects should note the lawsuits attacking runaway projects in recent months. When you form a crowdfunding campaign, you are accountable for your promises and claims.

One way campaigns can stay accountable is through two-way communication. If post-campaign failure is abundantly clear, quickly find a suitable resolution. Apologies only go so far, and as discussed before, delivering alternate perks typically angers supporters. By communicating, however, you can figure out the type of compensation your backers demand, even if that's a full refund.

For equity crowdfunding, escaping investors does not happen. In fact, investors legally bound to your startup have a host of rights. Most recognize the volatility of a startup, so don't bother hiding bumps in the path. Leading your investors blindly throws away the opportunity for advice. It also risks a few very unhappy investors seeking legal recompense.

Reciprocity

Help other projects get the right foot forward by donating or investing yourself. Call it gratitude, courtesy, or "paying it forward." Share with others the things you've learned during your campaign and contribute regularly to the industry. Reverse the roles, even if it is just to see what the other side is like.

VIII. ● CAVEAT! CAMPAIGN CRIPPLERS



Caveat! Campaign Crippleers

So far, we have covered oodles of information — and with reason. Anyone who thinks of crowdfunding as a shortcut needs to reconsider his or her stance on the industry. As with any professional or creative endeavour, a crowdfunding campaign requires forethought, dedication, and precision. That means exercising your market prowess, crunching numbers, and putting in the labour.

Following the previous chapters, you should not be surprised to learn there are various crowdfunding pitfalls. Thankfully, you can avoid most of them. No project runs seamlessly from beginning to end, so do not fret if one or two things go awry. Just remember to plan for the unexpected and implement a few disaster recovery strategies along the way.

Planning

Not all businesses suit crowdfunding. To date, the most successful projects have primarily dealt with consumer products in one form or another. In saying this, the industry continues to diversify, reaching new sectors like health care and real estate. As part of your portal research, investigate whether or not you fit into the industry. Furthermore, determine if you are ready to meet the crowd by conducting this review.

- **Status:** Analyze the stability and legitimacy of your project. What credentials does your business possess? Have you filed for patents or incorporated? Think legal and financial, as well as in terms of maturity.
- **Progress:** Is the product or idea as far as it can go, and if not, will crowdfunding take it there? Have you validated the business idea? Proof-of-concept is crucial, especially for equity crowdfunding.
- **Market:** Is there room for another project like yours on the market? Have your competitors tried their luck with the crowd? Do other businesses in your industry stay clear of this funding method?
- **Team:** Do you have the man- or woman-power to complete the project? Does everyone have enough time to commit? Can you handle the responsibility of producing and distributing perks? What about the demands of your potential shareholders?
- **Potential:** Is your project something people can truly get behind?

Financials

When a project surpasses a realistic goal – one unjustifiably high or overly optimistic – the chance of success dwindles. Steep minimums and expensive perks chase supporters away, especially those stumbling upon your page for the first time. That said, equity projects should look for higher portal minimums to prevent a flood of investors.

Unlike a rewards-based project, too many shareholders can strain a business' time and patience, while making future funding endeavours more difficult. An assortment of unsophisticated investors reflects poorly on a startup's credibility. This boils down to the “smart” versus “dumb” money argument: The difference between the advice and support of a seasoned investor and of one with little to offer besides cash.

Disclosing information, running background checks, producing and filing reports, and distributing

dividends, amongst a plethora of other responsibilities, all play into financial planning. Do not forget about your taxes either. In most cases, the government considers crowdfunding as taxable income, so research the laws in your local state/province/city. Seek the advice of an accountant or lawyer, as there may be wiggle room for deductibles and exemptions.

For equity projects, the financials often determine success – and justifiably so, as it is the most compressive section of the business plan. Rewards-based campaigns, however, can get easily sidetracked and forget about the expenses. Failing to consider these variables inevitably leads to failure and/or disappointment.

Usually, small goals are more appropriate. Through the use of stretch goals or follow-up campaigns, a project may generate more revenue if need be, but it's safer to target the bare necessities than to shoot too high and miss in front of your new and old supporters. Stick within reason to your project's budget and the market's average.

Marketing

Listing a project and hoping for the best will not end prosperously. Neither will aggressive marketing. Just as you would your financials, plan every aspect of your marketing campaign to avoid such things.

Specificity

All campaigns need a financial target, but a campaign requires other objectives as well. For example, a filmmaker approaches the crowd with a documentary proposal. Besides the movie's budget, the artist should ask him or herself, "What will this documentary achieve – justice, entertainment, awareness?" Rather than aiming just for a number, find the purpose and humanize the project. Once you have this, explicitly state it. Vagueness is a bad sign – always!

Diversity

After defining your objectives, diversify the method. Let's reiterate an earlier point: Treat all social portals independently. Communicate differently on your website's blog compared to LinkedIn or Facebook. This may seem like an insignificant detail, but members on such portals will notice how out of place your content is. With this in mind, avoid sticking just to your favourites. Although familiar, you need to expand your network as much as possible.

Similarly, should any technical difficulties arise (i.e. account suspension, hosting downtime, etc.), have alternative means of marketing ready to go. Without back up, you risk failure. By throwing additional contact information on your landing page, for instance, you create multiple means of communication. So set up an email, query form, and phone number to complement your social profiles. This shows supporters that you want them to reach out.

Scarcity

Before, after, and during a crowdfunding campaign, regularly update your social feeds. An absent or neglectful administrator poses two primary problems: Network stagnation and supporter dissatisfaction. By communicating with your social connections, you involve them in the process. This not only makes them feel in the loop, but also cherished and acknowledged.

Since most of your connections use their accounts for things outside of crowdfunding, be careful not to overdo it. Too much promotion invades their personal space. In the worst case, users will report you as spam, which could derail the campaign early on. Build a social schedule to reduce the risk of this happening. Also, create an etiquette guideline for each portal.

Courtesy

Respect the rules of courtesy and take time to share valuable information – that is, social updates not just about you and your campaign. This means apportioning other people's creations on your timeline. Responding to queries, interacting with followers, and keeping in touch have the same effect. Relationships strengthen the crowd; you never want supporters to feel used or exploited.

When it comes to email subscriptions, always ask permission. Never purchase mailing lists and disregard that impulse to use automated services. Such tools lead to the issues discussed above. Whenever possible, have another team member read over your social interactions before replying or posting. Sometimes you do not realize how impersonal a response sounds until someone tells you.

Branding

One aspect of crowdfunding attractive to many startups is visibility. Crowdfunding can help startups accrue customers and establish a strong market image. This we know. Unfortunately, here also lies one of the greatest crowdfunding pitfalls – a tarnished brand.

Through the traditional approach, a startup will likely face rejection a few times. Afterward, it is much easier to explain a failed loan application than a butchered crowdfunding campaign. The crowdfunding game is so transparent that failure can bereave a business of any second or third chances. That said, some campaigns do a good job leaving on a good note.

Campaigns that face failure as a stepping-stone fare the best after the fact. Those troubled by incensed supporters and malignant rumours do not. Even if your campaign doesn't hit its goal, look for the "silver lining." Did you learn anything about the market or about your venture? Simply letting a project die due to insufficient funds is a quick way to blemish a positive brand.

Revising

As with most things, sloppiness leads to mistakes. What sort of impression does your campaign have with noticeable spelling errors? Worse, what happens if your content baffles people? Your explanations may make perfect sense to you, but to a non-expert or a person with a different first language, these trip-ups can cause frightful damage.

Consider error checking other aspects of your camping too. For example, verify all hyperlinks work and that all images load properly. Double-check that your landing page opens on multiple devices (smartphones and tablets included). Then, ask some friends and colleagues to do the same. These things relate to project credibility – so get them right!

IX. APPENDIX



Appendix

Rewards-Based Crowdfunding

CrowdTilt: Campaigns fit into one of three categories -- collect and fundraise, split an expense, or sell something. The portal charges successful donation projects 2.5% and successful rewards-based campaigns 5% of the total funds raised.

Fundable: For businesses interested in rewards or equity crowdfunding solutions, they may create a free profile on Fundable. To eliminate the success fees found on most other portals, it costs projects \$179/month to crowdfund on this website.

FundRazr: For personal, group, political, or non-profit causes. There are no funding or campaign time limits, but all recipients pay 5% in the end.

Indiegogo: Accepts all types of projects and offers newcomers free educational support. Successful projects pay 4% of their fundraising goal and failed projects pay 9%.

Kickstarter: Various categories for crowdfunding exist, though the website restricts charities, awareness campaigns, and personal crowdfunding. Currently, limited countries may post projects. Kickstarter adopts the "all-or-nothing model" with a success fee of 5%.

NewJelly: Intended for artists and other creative professionals ready to embrace crowdfunding. NewJelly takes 6% of funds from successful campaigns. There is also a minimum funding limit of 100€.

Pozible: Arts, comics/graphic novels, community, design, event, fashion, film, food, game, music, journalism, performance, photography, technology, literature, video, and crafts projects welcomed. Pozible uses an "all-or-nothing model" with varying fees. New projects part with 5% should they reach their deadline, but previously successful project creators pay only 4%.

RocketHub: Looks for campaigns involved in arts, business, science, and social causes. It makes 4% commission on successful projects and 8% on unsuccessful ones.

Sponsume: Open to creative professionals interested in film, music, fashion, photography, theater, scientific research, technology, or the environment. It is another "keep-it-all" model in which failed projects pay nothing and successful projects pay 5%.

Subscription Crowdfunding

Patreon: Supports projects with YouTube channels, web comics, blogs, games, music, podcasts, animations, illustrations, photography, and more. Of these categories, it offers two subscription options: "Patronage per Content Release" and "Patronage per Month." Regardless of the two, Patreon takes 5%.

Subbable: Tailored to content creators of all kinds. In saying this, some projects may encounter conversion fees outside of the US. Typically, Subbable takes the common 5% of collected funds.

Donation Crowdfunding

Catalyst: Open to everyone devoted to making a positive social change. Although the portal provides projects with free workshops and resources, campaigns still part with 5% if successful. For unsuccessful projects, this fee jumps to 8%.

CauseVox: Non-profits in the United States, Canada, and Australia may choose from a selection of pay-as-you go packages, ranging from \$0 to \$129/month, or opt for a free trial plan, available to projects under \$5000. For all options, fees fall between 4% and 5%.

FirstGiving: Offers non-profits and charities educational material, but charges \$500 a year plus a 7.5% processing fee and 4.5% event registration fee.

FundAnything: Projects involved in art, business, education, film, medical, music, non-profit, volunteer, web work, and more will find a place here. The portal charges 9% on all collected donations, 4% of which the portal returns should the project reach its goal.

Giveeffect: Encourages Canadian charities targeting young donors to join. Giveeffect issues tax receipts to donors, but asks that 6.2% of donations go back into the portal.

GoFundMe: Personal projects like medical expenses, education, funerals, and pets accepted. Projects part with 5% of all donations.

Equity Crowdfunding

CircleUp: Connects accredited investors with innovative consumer and retail companies.

CrowdCube: Entrepreneurs pitch their businesses to investors, outlining the target amount and the equity offered. Issuers must cover a 250£ listing fee (currently waived) plus a 5% target deduction. Lastly, the portal charges 1,750£ (+ VAT) for the purposes of execution.

Early Shares: Only open to individuals considered Accredited Investors by the SEC (subject to change). Businesses must meet a series of requirements in order to participate, including an experienced management team, customer/user network, contracts, value proposition, and more.

Equity Net: Any entrepreneur or business owner may list, with the exception of public-traded companies. Paid subscriptions start at \$69. Since Equity Net is not a registered broker dealer, the website does not take commissions.

Invesdor: Boasts a wide range of investment opportunities. It costs companies 500€ (+ VAT) to list, plus a success fee of 6%. Investors outside of Finland must also pay an administration fee of 2.42% (+ VAT).

Rock the Post: Meant for high-growth startups with a viable product and traction.

Seedrs: Targets seed-stage startups in the UK. Eligible businesses may receive one of two tax relief schemes: the Seed Enterprise Investment Scheme (SEIS) or the Enterprise Investment Scheme (EIS). Successful projects pay 7.5% of total funds raised to Seedrs.

SeedsUp: Early stage and growth companies compliant with Canada's National Instrument 45-106, Prospectus and Registration Exemptions, and its companion Blanket Order 45-512. Projects pay a success fee in-line with other traditional banking transactions.

StartupValley: Technology startups and businesses, including those involved in app development, web design, social networking, health care, science, and energy technology. StartupValley offers free project submission with a success fee of 5%.

truCrowd: Open to US residences under the age of eighteen; companies must incorporate before listing with truCrowd. While in beta, truCrowd will not charge the issuer or investor.

WeFund.me: Non-US citizens may invest as little as \$100 in any startup. The portal earns 10% interest on listed startups plus a \$25 transaction fee for various utilities including electronic signatures and legal templates.

Debt Crowdfunding

Assetz Capital: Requires a minimum investment of £20/loan — no lender fees.

Funding Circle: Loans from individuals, private organizations, councils, schools, and government to UK businesses. Simple fee structure for loans six to twelve months, two to three years, and four to five years. Rates between 2-4% for loans under 1,000,000£.

Lending Club: Both personal and business loans available. Low fixed rates with no hidden fees or prepayment penalties.

Prosper: Peer-to-peer lending between \$2,000 and \$35,000, with APR from 6.73% to 35.36% for best borrowers. Transaction fees vary per loan.

Zidisha: International peer-to-peer lending, but borrowers are primarily located in low-income countries where loans are otherwise unavailable. Businesses incur a transaction fee of 5%.

Zopa: Loans available between £1,000 and £20,000. All APR rates include both the interest paid to lenders and to the portal. The Zopa Market determines the total amount of interest paid.

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As a frequent writer for CrowdClan, a leading provider of educational crowdfunding material, I feature many concepts from this book on the website. For additional resources and explanations, please stop by and browse the archives. Drop a comment or find me online to discuss things further.

Below, you will find a suggested reading list. As an avid industry reader, this list documents only a few of the resources used in this book, primarily those I refer to explicitly. The rest comes from exposure and observation, as well as a background in business writing and communications.

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